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'Read ten thousand books, walk ten thousand miles': geographical mobility and capital accumulation among Chinese scholars

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International movements of scientists and researchers have become more common in the increasingly interconnected global knowledge economy. Geographic mobility is often perceived as a key to academic excellence and career advancement by scholars, especially in advanced economies. In China, where international geographical mobility is a newly-gained privilege after the advent of the Open Door Policy, academics belong to one of the most mobile subsets of the population. This paper interrogates the impact of academic mobility at the individual level among Chinese scholars who have conducted research visits in Germany. Specifically, the paper operationalises the equivocal notion of personal development with the concepts of capital accumulation and conversion (after Pierre Bourdieu). Drawing upon findings from 64 in-depth interviews with Chinese scholars of postdoctoral level or above and six key informants, and a postal survey (123 Chinese scholars with mobility biography to Germany), this paper illustrates how geographical mobility can be conceptualised as a form of capital that can be accumulated and converted to cultural, social, economic and symbolic capital. While geographical mobility is predominantly considered as a capital for positive self- and professional development, examples also demonstrate the potential detrimental effect on social capital, especially among young Chinese scholars. Using an agent-centred approach, this paper argues against a mechanical translation of geographical mobility to capital accumulation, but for a grounded understanding of the highly individualised and contextualised development processes.

Key words academic mobility; development studies; capital accumulation/conversion; Bourdieu; China; Germany

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Introduction

International movements of scientists and researchers have become more common in the global knowledge economy. Regular exchanges and collaborations with colleagues overseas have indeed become a necessary component of scholars' work, especially among those in advanced economies, where scholars generally have more resources to be mobile. Geographic mobility is often perceived as a key to academic excellence and career advancement by scholars. This resonates with the appreciation of geographical mobility as productive spatiality for learning and self-development in Chinese culture, as captured in a popular proverb, 'Read ten thousand books, walk ten thousand miles' ('*dú wàn juǎn shū, xíng wànlí lù*') – an old saying that emphasises the importance of book-learning (theoretical understanding) and practical experience gained through travel and field observation as two essential and complementary ways of knowing. The developmental impact of academic mobility is not only a personal matter. Ever more institutions worldwide are involved in stimulating the global circulation of academics, hoping that the geographical mobility of their affiliated scholars will have positive effects on their institution's position in the global knowledge network and achievement in expertise production. As nation states, urban centres and academic institutions compete to host or at least share affiliation with the highest quantity and quality of talents, the movement of these increasingly mobile scholars has become a contested field. The production of policy-related publications and the organisation of workshops by national and international institutions (e.g. OECD Workshop on the International Mobility of Researchers held in 2007; Thorn and Holm-Nielsen 2006) reflects the rising importance of this subset of mobility. Relatively unmotivated by the booming interest (or hype, as considered by many) in mobility represented by popularised metaphors such as 'spaces of flows' (Castells 2000), 'liquid modernity' (Bauman 2000) and the call for a 'new mobilities paradigm' (Sheller and Urry 2006), research by geographers and others interested in the movements of this mobile population has only recently taken shape. This inadequate attention is surprising, given the strategic importance of this group

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as agents who can shape the production, exchange and spread of knowledge as well as culture and associated practices (Ackers 2005; Blumenthal *et al*. 1996), which in turn contribute to the competitiveness of knowledge-producing structures ranging from individual academic institutions to urban centres, from nation state to world regions at large (Jöns 2009).

In general public discourses, these mobile academics, scientists and researchers are seen foremost as agents who engender development that is materialised in collective structures. Considered as the best and brightest among migrants, mobile academics are generally constructed as the embodiment of resources for social, economic and technical development. In the academic field, these 'development sites' are nested structures such as the scholars' laboratories, departments, academic disciplines, universities, cities, provinces, nations and even world regions. In arguing for a rethinking of popular notions in the migration–development nexus, Raghuram (2009, 104) problematises, among other conventions, how migrants have been seen as 'direct bearers of developmental objectives' that are positioned at collective levels (e.g. nation-state). I concur with her critique and argue that too little attention has been paid in the scholarship to the lived experiences of academic mobility, and hence the developmental impact of mobility at the individual level. Without a grounded understanding of the meanings of mobility at the personal level, of what these individuals' motivations and expectations are, and how they experience personal and professional growth as a result of their mobility biographies, a blind translation of x number of returnees to y amount of developmental impact on the broader society would only be partial. Such a spatial bias and limit in analyses overlooks the organic aspects of this mobility–development nexus.[1]

This paper examines the impact of academic mobility, focusing on the developmental experiences of Chinese scholars active in the Chinese–German academic field, using an agent-centred approach.[2] Substantiated with rich qualitative interview data, it maps out how academic mobility can be harnessed (or not) as resource or capital (after Pierre Bourdieu) for personal growth and professional development, and how the changes in these varied forms of capital in turn affect an individual's further geographical and social mobility. The remainder of the paper is organised into six sections. The first section provides an overview of related scholarship on academic mobility among academics and researchers. Bourdieu's notion of capital will then be discussed in connection with academic mobility in the second section. It proposes to conceptualise geographical mobility as a form of capital (in addition to the different kinds of capital), highlighting the productive potential of mobility in the transnational(ising) academic field in our increasingly globalised knowledge economy. Such a conceptual framework also bridges the 'capital' and 'mobilities' scholarship on the academic context that have both been vibrant but remained by and large disconnected. The paper then proceeds to chart the recent trends in international academic mobility among Chinese scholars with geographical focus on the transnational Chinese–German academic field. The fifth section uncovers some exemplary capital accumulation and conversion processes experienced by my research participants. Finally, the paper will conclude with some implications of this study in unsettling conventional scalar conceptualisation of mobility-related development and refining our approaches in understanding the meanings and transforming power of geographical mobility.

Academic mobility research: an overview

Academic mobility refers to the academically motivated geographical movements of students, faculty and researchers, generally in higher education, from their home institution to another one, either inside or outside of their home country, to study, teach or take part in research for a period of time. As higher education becomes more internationalised, this type of temporary international academic mobility has also become more common. As Robertson recently observed, "'Mobility" is all the rage in the academy' today, 'in all corners of the globe' (2010, 641). While we must recognise that most students, staff, programmes, related objects and knowledge (and hence power and influence) in the world are not mobile, the stretching and deepening of, and the rising importance attached to mobility in the academic field deserves more critical analyses.

This paper concerns international academic staff mobility. Compared with research on student mobility, the study on academics had a late start, partially due to its transient nature and (hence) a lack of related data. The conference proceeding edited by Blumenthal *et al*. (1996) represents a pioneer effort in providing an overview of the development and patterns of academic mobility, among students and faculty staff, in different parts of the world. As borders within the European Union (EU) have gradually been taken down for Europeans, academic mobility within the EU has been promoted. This rise in mobility has stimulated a number of research projects, often focusing on the ramification and impact of certain policies or programmes such as ERASMUS (e.g. Ackers 2005 2010; Ackers and Balch 2009; Ackers and Gill 2008; Cox 2008; Enders and Teichler 2005; Hoffman 2009;

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Morano-Foadi 2000; Universities UK 2009). More specifically, in the German context, Jöns' (2009) research on scholars supported by the Alexander von Humboldt Foundation represents a rare and solid effort in analysing the long-term impact of academic mobility in academics' professional development with an impressive volume of survey data. Examining the impact of skilled migration in host societies, a recent survey-based project by Föbker *et al*. (2010) gauges the 'settlement' experiences of foreign academic staff employed by the Universities of Aachen, Bonn and Cologne. Operating within a classical assimilation/integration framework, the project evaluates how deeply foreign academics are integrated in Germany and their respective city of residence.

Beyond Europe, the Asia-Pacific region, where cross-border education (including the mobility of persons, programmes and institutions) is also very vibrant, has stimulated a number of academic mobility studies. Drawing on survey data from Asia-Pacific, Woolley *et al*. (2008) contend that international research training and early career research positions in places like the USA are mobility mechanisms that enable the acquisition of scientific capabilities and the building and integrating of knowledge networks. Yang and Welch (2010) consider 'the Chinese knowledge diaspora' in Australia as transnational human capital to be garnered by China and Australia. Questioning the assumed power of territory, identification and citizenship on the subjectivities of mobile academics, however, Fahey and Kenway (2010a) debunk the nexus between mobility, nation-state and belonging, and analyse the narratives of 24 of Australia's mobile researchers. The 'diaspora option' as the preferred development strategy in China has also been well-illustrated in Zweig *et al.* (2004 2008), marking a shift from the conventional brain-gain vis-à-vis brain-drain paradigm (Zweig and Chen 1995). Nevertheless, the (potential) 'brain-drain' effect caused by academic mobility, especially from poorer economies, continues to be a dark side of the mostly glorified 'mobility turn' in the academy (Thorn and Holm-Nielsen 2006; Welch 2008). At the personal level, academic mobility has mostly been presented as positive and empowering for the mobile individuals in the literature. A few studies have, however, highlighted its gender bias (Ackers 2010; Ackers and Balch 2009; Welch 2008) and the intrinsic favouritism toward mobility (and hence bias against those who are not mobile for whatever reasons) (Ackers 2010).

Engaging more deliberately with the body of mobilities research (Adey 2009; Cresswell 2006; Hannam *et al.* 2006; Sheller 2011; Sheller and Urry 2006), a number of scholars have widened the optic through which 'academic (im)mobilities' have been studied. Barnett and Phipps (2005) delineate geographical, epistemological and ontological forms of academic travel, extending the analytical focus beyond corporeal movements of academics to the boundary-crossing that occurs virtually in cyberspace and metaphorically across disciplinary divides, the theoretical/practical binary and audience groups. Taking the deconstruction work further, Fahey and Kenway (2010b) highlight the constitutive nature of knowledge, hence delinking simple notions such as 'moving academics = moving knowledge'. Decoupling this linkage is essential because studying academic mobility should (also) be about understanding the 'geographies of power/knowledge' and tracking 'an academic's movements (and frictions) within, and across, the different (political) terrains of academic knowledge production' (Robertson 2010, 644). Contributing to this emerging literature, this paper also places mobility at the centre of the inquiry, teasing out its multiple meanings and dynamics, and the ways it is enacted and experienced by individuals. In particular, it explores how mobility is viewed and practised as resource or capital for the academics, and other agents and institutions related to these individuals.

Conceptualising geographical mobility as capital

This paper interrogates the meanings and impact of academic mobility among Chinese academics, focusing on the perceived accumulation (or shrinkage) and conversion of social, cultural and symbolic capital. Rather than treating mobility as a process during which the accumulation and conversion of capital take place (hence, existing as a frame or backdrop), this papers centres on mobility and argues for integrating it into the capital framework. Specifically, geographical mobility is considered a form of capital that operates relationally with other forms of capital as conceptualised by Pierre Bourdieu. Building upon Marx's concept, Bourdieu defines capital broadly as 'accumulated, human labour' that can potentially produce different forms of profits (1986, 241). Capital, taking various material (physical, economic) and immaterial (cultural, social, symbolic) forms, is understood as resources within a society. The acquisition of these resources gives access to power and ultimately to material wealth. Depending on the topic in focus, Bourdieu operated with different categorisations of capital. The fundament was elaborated in 'The forms of capital' (Bourdieu 1986), where capital is principally differentiated into four categories: (i) economic capital as in income and other forms of financial resources and assets; (ii) social capital existing in durable social relations, networks and contacts; (iii) cultural capital of a person (e.g. competence, skills, qualifications), which takes three forms, namely

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objectified (e.g. books, computers), embodied (characteristics of a person, e.g. accent or multilingualism), and institutionalised forms (e.g. university degree or affiliation with prestigious research institution); and finally (iv) symbolic capital is used to explain the manner in which various forms of capital are perceived in a corresponding social structure, such as the prestige or status value attached to certain competencies, values, and/or places of learning and research. In his seminal work in academic sociology *Homo academicus*, Bourdieu (1988) provides a detailed analysis of French academia as a field of capital power struggle where prestige, esteem and careers are built, negotiated and disrupted, especially along disciplinary boundaries. In a somewhat deterministic way, Bourdieu tabulates the social origins and connections, economic and political resources, academic biographies, titles, professional practices, honour and political stances of the faculty members. He analyses his data by typifying the most relevant capital in the field of academia into 'educational capital', 'capital of academic power', 'capital of scientific power and prestige', 'capital of intellectual renown' and 'capital of political or economic power'. He concludes that French academia is essentially a conservative institution that reproduces and reinforces social class distinctions, because it is populated by members of the privileged class who have a vested interest in preserving the status quo. Bourdieu condemns such a system as it encourages conformity rather than innovation. In his later work, *The state nobility*, Bourdieu (1996) sharpens his critique, underlining the central role of the French elite higher education system in perpetuating social domination by the elites. Here, Bourdieu works with a less specified notion of 'academic capital' to denote a form of cultural capital accumulated through prior educational achievement, specially designated competencies and a disposition to be 'academic' as expressed in one's manner in speaking and writing. Social origin defines heavily the transmission and accumulation of academic capital, according to Bourdieu's data-laden analysis.

In this paper, I adopt the construct presented in 'The forms of capital' (Bourdieu 1986) and examine, in particular, the convertibility of different forms of capital to each other. Indeed, such 'exchange rate' is of critical importance in Bourdieu's capital framework. Operating with constraints, social and cultural capital, for instance, are particularly valuable if they can be converted into other types of capital, such as (or especially) economic capital in our capitalistic world. By the same token, economic capital becomes more worthwhile if it can readily be converted to social and cultural capital. Here, I propose to consider geographical mobility as a form of capital in the field of academia, alongside other forms of cultural (e.g. academic qualifications, intellectual capacity), social (e.g. membership of prestigious academic associations), symbolic (e.g. publications in high-impact journals) and economic capital (e.g. research grants and access to other budgets). It is based on the hypothesis that geographical mobility can be conceptualised as 'a set of actually usable resources and power' (Bourdieu 1984, 114) that can be converted into other forms of capital, which subsequently can be accumulated and transformed to further mobility, both in geographical (as in subsequent overseas travelling for varied purposes) and social (as in personal and career advancement) senses. Integrating geographical mobility into the analytical framework adds to Bourdieu's exclusive focus on social (im)mobility in his study of the academic field. By looking at the convertibility of capital in transnational academic space, this study also extends Bourdieu's (often criticised) Franco-centric empirical scope, linking it to the burgeoning scholarly work on mobilities in transnational spheres.

My proposition of conceptualising geographical mobility as a form of capital relates to the work of a number of scholars who have, from different perspectives, brought 'mobility' and 'capital' together. In a more generalised sense, Kaufmann *et al*. (2004) theorise the notion of motility, the capacity to be mobile geographically and socially, as a form of capital in modern societies. Developing from this theoretical paper, Flamm and Kaufmann go further to assert that 'spatial mobility has become so crucial that it has become an established ideology' (2006, 167), the *Zeitgeist*. Murphy-Lejeune (2002) considers 'mobility capital' as a subset of human capital acquired by students studying overseas, underlining how 'the richness of the international experience' may translate into graduates' success in the labour market. Together with other scholars interested in the development effect of academic mobility among students, Murphy-Lejeune concludes that the accumulation of human capital through international education contributes to the (re)production of social privileges (Brooks and Waters 2009; Findlay and King 2010; Ong 1999; Waters 2006). Few studies have made an explicit effort in examining the processes of capital accumulation and conversion. An exception is the insightful study by Xiang and Shen (2009). It examines the impact of international academic mobility among Chinese students, tracing how human, social, political and cultural capital of student returnees transforms into each other, and thereby concluding that such conversion mostly exacerbates the existing social stratification in China. This echoes the observation by Liu (1997), who demonstrates how mobility is a strategy for economic and symbolic capital formation among Chinese peasants and scholars, both in China and overseas.

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Liu's example of Chinese students and researchers illustrates the desire of Chinese people to translate academic mobility into wealth accumulation or permanent residence overseas. Focusing on the impact of mobility on scholars' career development, Kim (2010) advocates the notion 'transnational identity capital', highlighting the positively transformative nature of mobility on academics' identity capital (after Côte and Levine 2008). Using a quantitative approach and focusing on the legal profession, Dinovitzer and Hagan (2006) study the 'career consequences' of intra-national mobility among Canadian lawyers using two datasets. They conceptualise geographical mobility as a 'meaningful career contingency' and 'professional transition' that can alter the forms and value of one's human, social and symbolic capital, that in turn can be valorised for his/her advancement in the legal field.

Mobile scholars in the Chinese–German academic field: recent trends

After its adoption of the Open Door Policy in 1978, China became more integrated into the world system and Chinese academics also gained geographical mobility and intensified their participation in the global knowledge economy. As mentioned earlier, systematic, internationally comparable data on the mobility of academic staff are not available, as confirmed in a recent study published by the European Commission and the Ministry of Education in China (GHK Consulting and Renmin University 2011) for which only Germany, Finland, Portugal, Sweden and the UK (out of 27 member states) provided statistics relating to the numbers of Chinese academic staff in higher education. Their figures showed that at least 6697 academic staff of Chinese nationality worked in the EU between 2008 and 2009. Most of them were working at German and UK higher education institutions (Table I). The figures indicated the number of academic staff with Chinese nationality, irrespective of how long they have been in the specific country, reflecting the challenge in interpreting migration/mobility data. These data can therefore not be read as a perfect indicator of genuine academic mobility. According to the Chinese Ministry of Education, academics going to Europe are generally aged between 30 and 40 years, male and from disciplines related to engineering. They are mostly affiliated with institutions located in Beijing or Shanghai. Academic mobility of Chinese scholars to Europe is steadily increasing and these scholars mostly travel to Europe for short-term periods (3 months to 1 year) (GHK Consulting and Renmin University 2011). Mobility patterns vary greatly depending on academic disciplines, the existence of exchange programmes, academic networks and sponsorship among other factors. While the USA is commonly referred to in published studies, anecdotal references and my fieldwork data as the 'number one destination' among many Chinese academics, there are no comprehensive data available to verify this preference. National data also cannot capture the intra-national geographical pattern of mobility of academic staff, which is particularly important in understanding academic mobility as the resource base and 'quality' of institutions within one country can be much greater than the difference between countries. It is, hence, not surprising that 'Improving data collection on learning mobility to support evidence-based policy making' is the first and foremost recommendation put forth in the EU report (GHK Consulting and Renmin University 2011, 102).

This paper focuses on contemporary Chinese academic mobility, but it should nevertheless be mentioned that Chinese–German academic mobility has a long history. Kaderas and Meng (2000) and Meng (2005) provide comprehensive and valuable historical information on Chinese students in Germany since

Table I Academic staff mobility from China to the EU

Country		*2005*	*2006*	*2007*	*2008*
Finland		34	32	36	48
Germany	Scientific staff of Chinese nationality	1027	1174	1298	1636
	Chinese scientists exchange programme	1535	1678	1779	2199

Country	*2004/05*	*2005/06*	*2006/07*	*2007/08*	*2008/09*
Portugal	10	12	11	12	9
	Gender ratio: approximately 50/50				
Sweden	18	18	18	26	35
UK					2770 (1780 male; 990 female)

Source: GHK Consulting and Renmin University (2011, 49).

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the mid-1860s. Ji *et al*. (2000) document the life and work experiences of 50 Chinese scholars who spent a period of time in Germany during the 20th century. Prominent figures include important politicians, the first Premier of the People's Republic of China Zhou Enlai and the first Vice Chairman Zhu De. The intensity of interactions between Chinese and German scholars has fluctuated with the changes in the bilateral political-economic relationship. A high level of vitality can be observed in recent years. In addition to the rapidly expanding numbers of exchange programmes, sponsorship and partnership between academic and research institutions, special initiatives such as The German–Chinese Year of Science and Education 2009/2010 have been organised to boost cooperation in higher education, promote professional training and collaboration in cutting-edge research.[3] According to recent data from the China Scholarship Council (CSC), Germany ranks among the top as host for Chinese scholars of different levels. Though lagging much (about 50%) behind the USA, Germany was the second most favourite destination among Chinese doctoral students who pursue their degree overseas, with 481 out of a total of 4892 CSC scholarships under the '5000 PhD Scholarships Programme (2007–2011)' being allotted to Germany-bound doctoral students (Hase-Bergen 2009). Under the framework of the State-Sponsored Study Abroad Programme in 2007, 807 of the 12 402 grantees, comprising graduate students and visiting scholars, would be hosted by German universities and research institutions. Here, Germany ranks fourth behind the USA (n=5130), the UK (n=1537) and Australia (n=869), but ahead of Canada (n=738), Japan (n=514), Russia (n=490) and France (n=459), hence placing it the first among non-English-speaking countries. (China Scholarship Council 2008). China as a source of visiting academics is also important from the German perspective. Figure 1 illustrates the rising trend in the number of Chinese academics and researchers in Germany between 1999 and 2009. In 2009, China ranked first as origin of foreign post-docs in Germany (Table II), second as origin of foreign academics and researchers/university teachers (Table III). Figure 2 shows the discipline background of Chinese academics and researchers in Germany in 2009.

Focusing on mobility as an experience, this paper goes beyond reducing the vitality along the China–Germany academic mobility corridor to a set of numbers.[4] Before we turn to the qualitative fieldwork data, a description and some reflection on the project setting and methodology are in order.

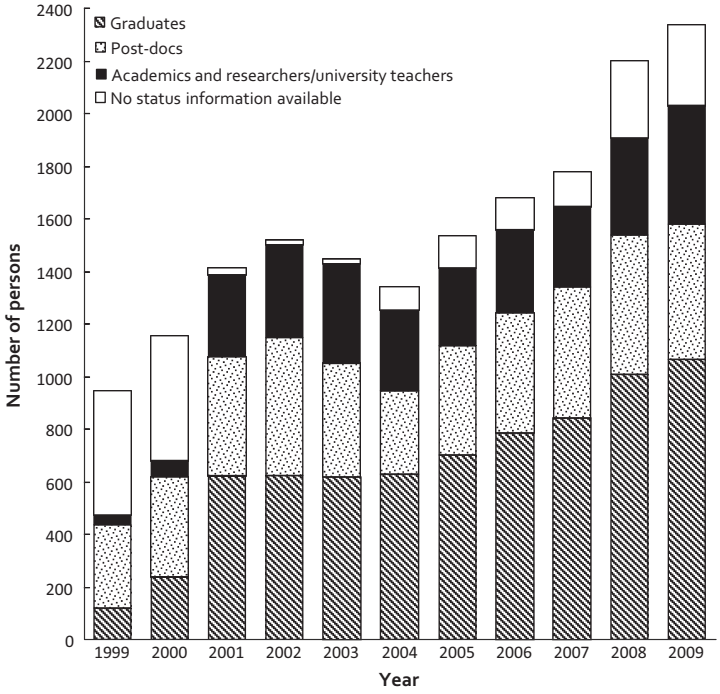

Figure 1 Number of Chinese graduates, post-docs, academics, researchers and university teachers in Germany (1999–2009)

Source: Wissenschaft weltoffen (http://www.wissenschaftweltoffen.de/daten/7/2/3?lang=en, accessed 25 November 2011)

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Table II Foreign post-docs in Germany in 2009: the 20 quantitatively most important countries of origin

Rank	*Countries of origin*	*Number*	*2008 = 100*	*in % of all post-docs*
1	China	514	97.2	12.5
2	India	348	107.4	8.5
3	United States	285	121.8	6.9
4	Russian Federation	221	94.4	5.4
5	Japan	126	99.2	3.1
6	Italy	125	133.0	3.0
7	France	115	104.5	2.8
8	Poland	96	89.7	2.3
9	Spain	91	116.7	2.2
10	Canada	65	116.1	1.6
11	United Kingdom	58	105.5	1.4
12	Australia	53	89.8	1.3
13	Ukraine	44	112.8	1.1
14	Israel	39	68.4	1.0
15	Hungary	36	83.7	0.9
16	Netherlands	33	106.5	0.8
17	Austria	30	103.4	0.7
18	Czech Republic	28	121.7	0.7
19	Romania	27	90.0	0.7
20	Brazil	23	82.1	0.6

Source: http://www.wissenschaftweltoffen.de/daten/7/2/6?lang=en. (Accessed 25 November 2011)

Table III Foreign academics and researchers/university teachers in Germany in 2009: the 20 most important (by number) countries of origin

Rank	*Countries of origin*	*Number*	*2008 = 100*	*in % of all funded recipients*
1	Russian Federation	2,408	114.7	8.1
2	China	2,338	106.3	7.9
3	United States	1,93	130.2	6.5
4	India	1,679	115.6	5.6
5	Italy	972	137.1	3.3
6	Poland	887	108.6	3.0
7	France	827	134.9	2.8
8	Ukraine	579	124.8	1.9
9	Spain	570	127.8	1.9
10	Brazil	560	106.7	1.9
11	United Kingdom	555	151.2	1.9
12	Japan	492	106.7	1.7
13	Mexico	479	112.4	1.6
14	Pakistan	433	100.0	1.5
15	Austria	402	154.0	1.4
16	Colombia	364	117.0	1.2
17	Netherlands	360	155.8	1.2
18	Turkey	360	105.0	1.2
19	Romania	353	96.7	1.2
20	Hungary	341	119.6	1.1

Source: http://www.wissenschaftweltoffen.de/daten/7/2/4?lang=en. (Accessed 25 November 2011)

Methodology

Data illustrated in this paper originate from fieldwork conducted between 2009 and 2010. The study began with the implementation of a two-page survey to generate an overview and collect quantifiable data from Chinese scholars of post-doctoral level or above who have conducted research visits (of minimum duration 3 months) in Germany.[5] The survey was distributed through diverse channels to maximise the number of 'entrances to the field': (i) as an attachment to the December 2009 issue of the DAAD (The German Academic Exchange Service) China newsletter *DAAD China Info* (sent to 4500 alumni at that time, most of whom had however been doctoral candidates in Germany, hence not in my 'sample range'), (ii) as an email attachment to 162 former recipients of fellowship and prizes from the Alexander von Humboldt Foundation who had made their contacts available on the Foundation website, (iii) as hardcopy at the Sino-German Geography Alumni Meeting (2009) in Guangzhou that was attended by about 40 geographers, (iv) personal contacts, and (v) snowballing by asking participants to forward the questionnaires to their colleagues with the sought mobility profile. By the end of the collection period, 123 completed questionnaires were received (three more than the target of 120). Given the lack of a population frame, it is not possible to know how statistically representative the sample is. Among the respondents, 94 were male and 29 female, in their mid-20s to late-70s with the majority being aged between mid-30s and 50, having held positions ranging from post-doctoral researcher to professor during their visit(s) in Germany. The distribution of participants' disciplinary background is summarised in Table IV. While the survey was executed to reach a broad and representative sample in order to collect more generalisable data for the identification of meaningful patterns and the generation of interview questions, statistical representativeness was not aimed for. The 'over-proportional' representation of scholars in law, economics/business administration, social sciences, for example, can partially be explained by the background of the researcher – being a geographer having more contacts with colleagues in geography and related fields in social sciences (and geology and agricultural science). There can also be a link between academics' disciplinary background and the levels of willingness to participate in a survey of social science nature.

Subsequently, interviews were conducted, with 64 in person or by telephone. Interviewees were invited by way of the survey and personal contacts. Efforts were made to ensure diversity in gender, age, academic rank and disciplines represented. Among the interviewees, 18 were female and 46 male. Their age ranged from mid-20s to mid-70s, having held position(s) ranging from post-doctoral researcher to professor at the time of their visit(s) in Germany. Their disciplinary background is presented in Table IV. While the interview data reveal a certain level of

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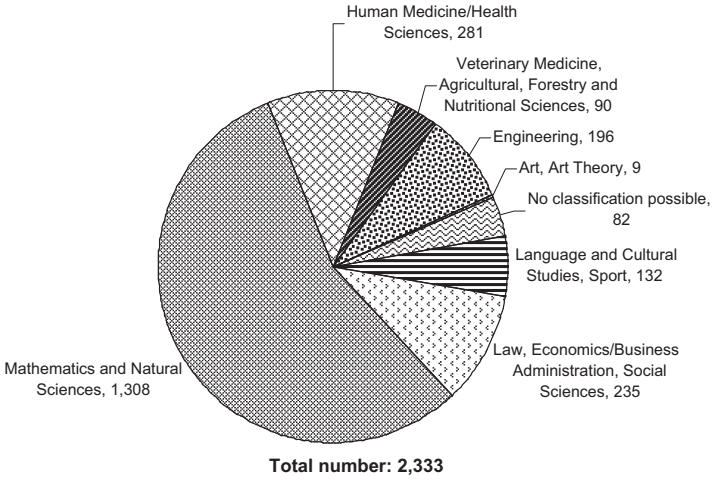

Figure 2 Discipline background among Chinese academics and researchers in Germany in 2009 (number of persons)

Source: http://www.wissenschaftweltoffen.de/daten/7/3/8?lang=en (Accessed 25 November 2011)

Note: The slight discrepancy between the total number of Chinese academics and researchers in Germany listed in Table II and this figure arises because the Friedrich-Naumann-Stiftung did not have data on the fields of research of the academics and researchers they funded in 2009 (personal communication with HIS Hochschul-Informations-System GmbH, which is responsible for the preparation and analysis of the data presented on wissenschaftweltoffen.de)

Table IV Discipline background of survey and interview participants

Discipline category	*Number of survey participants*	*Proportion*	*Number of interviewees*	*Proportion*
Mathematics and Natural Sciences	41	33%	16	25%
Law, Economics/Business Administration, Social Sciences	35	28%	26	40%
Engineering	24	20%	11	17%
Human Medicine/Health Sciences	13	11%	5	8%
Veterinary Medicine, Agricultural, Forestry and Nutritional Sciences	8	7%	5	7%
Language and Cultural Studies, Sport	2	2%	1	2%
Art, Art Theory	0	0%	0	0%
Total:	123	100%	64	100%

Note: The categorisation follows the schema used on wissenschaftweltoffen.de to facilitate comparison with the data published on the website (cf. Figure 2). The categorisation was, however, not always a straightforward exercise because many researchers work across boundaries conventionally set between the seven board categories used.

'data saturation', each and every interview conducted remained unique and contributed added value to the study. The final number of interviews conducted in this project was more a result of time and budget availability. The exact content of each interview varied, depending on the background and mobility biography of the interviewee. They were, however, guided to collect the following core information: (i) the interviewee's biography, in particular information relevant to his/her intention to travel, (ii) his/her motivations for arranging academic visit(s) to Germany, (iii) the impact of his/her academic visit(s) both professionally and personally and (iv) the meanings of geographical mobility in their professional and personal life. In addition, expert interviews with six representatives of German organisations involved in academic mobility programmes for Chinese scholars and three with Chinese officials were also conducted in Bonn, Cologne and Beijing. The face-to-face interviews followed a semi-structured format, covering (i) the basic information of the institution, (ii) the objectives, history and structure of programmes promoting academic mobility of Chinese scholars, (iii) an evaluation of existing programmes and (iv) plans for future programmes. The interviews were conducted in Mandarin Chinese or German. They lasted between 1 and 2.5 hours. All interviews were audio-recorded and fully transcribed for analysis. Pseudonyms are used

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for individuals, their institutions and, when considered necessary, their specialities in order to maintain the anonymity of research participants.

Geographical mobility as capital among Chinese academics

In the following, experiences, perceptions and reflections of research participants will be provided to illustrate how academic mobility, as a form of capital, interacts with other forms of capital. Narratives presented below are exemplary because they illuminate recognisable patterns in the findings. The illustration is intended to be indicative rather than exhaustive. The quotations are used here more to demonstrate how geographical mobility can be conceptualised as a form of capital with a context-specific, fluctuating 'conversion rate' vis-à-vis other forms of capital. The vignettes should, therefore, not read as a one-to-one reflection – which would have been a caricature at best – of the personalised and contextualised experiences and perceptions observed in the field.

I shall analyse relevant fieldwork materials in this sequence: cultural, social, symbolic and finally economic capital. Not surprisingly scholars sent overseas are expected to attain cultural capital during their work abroad, which subsequently should elevate the positioning of their affiliated institute(s) and academic discipline in the world league. Hu Li (female, early 40s), associate professor in electronics information explained what her 'mission' to Germany (2006–2007) was:

> I was supposed to take a look at how they teach in Germany, how the curriculum is organised and what kind of facilities they have … because our university aims to upgrade itself to a world class institution. … And our university also expected me to elevate my ability in research.

Most of my respondents confirmed that their research ability and mentality had gone through positive changes. Data generated from my survey show that slightly more than half of the respondents (63 out of 123) considered that his/her experiences in Germany had strengthened his/her competitiveness in the academic field to a large extent ('5' in a scale of '1' to '5'), while 29 individuals (24%) gave the rank of '4' and 10 (8%) gave the neutral rank of '3'. Common self-evaluations heard during qualitative interviews include becoming 'more serious', 'more structured', 'more solid' and 'less fixated on just blindly pushing sub-standard publications out'.

For Zhong Hong (female, mid-30s), lecturer in urban geography, being in Germany was 'very eye-opening' (*dàkāi yǎnjiè*) – an expression used by many of my interviewees. Her daily life and work experiences provided her with alternative perspectives:

> Here, you learn that things can be done differently. We can do research in a different way; we can plan our cities in a different way. Even letting passengers get on the train without passing through a gate is possible! In China, that is unthinkable.

By being overseas, she found herself being able to think beyond her old horizon:

> I had to prepare a seminar on the electronic industry in the Pearl River Delta. In China, I would have started my presentation with the Chinese national context, and then get to the Pearl River Delta case. But here, it dawned on me that there is also a world out there, a world trend in terms of development in electronic industry. So that was where I began my lecture. I now look at things with a global perspective, rather than a China-centred one.

Indeed, an ability to think beyond 'the China box' and make linkages to broader contexts is considered a desirable competency in China where linkages to overseas colleagues and institutions, though becoming rapidly more common, are still highly limited to a small privileged group. Related to the ability to 'connect to the world', the opportunity to practise and publish in English (*not* German) was also frequently noted as a source and evidence of professional development. While almost all of my interviewees have provided positive judgement as to this aspect of capital accumulation, it is necessary to emphasise that Chinese scholars are not always 'climbing up' the knowledge hierarchy because they have spent time in the global North per se. As a matter of fact, in China (and some other emerging economies), the differences between research institutions or laboratories of particular disciplines (especially in the natural and medical sciences and engineering) of varied tiers (e.g. between the renowned 'world-class' Tsinghua University and a weakly-endowed university in a poor province) are greater than those between institutions of similar class across the global North–South divide (e.g. between Tsinghua University and Harvard University). For some scholars with a background in 'strategic' fields that are well-supported in China, their academic visits to Germany are opportunities for equal-footing exchanges with colleagues, which contribute to cultural capital accumulation for the Chinese visiting scholars *and* their counterparts in Germany. Reflecting upon his work in promoting academic mobility between China and Germany, a key informant who works for an important funding organisation that supports German–Chinese research collaborations confirmed the evolved relationship:

> At the beginning, the Chinese of course benefited more from the fact that they came to Germany, because the aid or help aspect from the German side was still an important element 30 years ago. … Meanwhile, it operates on the principle of cooperation, on equal-footing. It is always co-financing for projects. The Chinese and we pay for each

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> side of the project and now we also emphasise that the projects are balanced. So not like before, when we paid for Chinese scholars to come for a longer period of time and the Germans only went to China for a conference. Now, the German scholars, especially the younger researchers, should also go to China for a longer period.

As an experienced researcher who speaks fluent Chinese and is well-embedded in the Chinese academic circle, my informant was able to trace the development of the nature and quality of academic encounter between the Germans and the Chinese in the course of the last two decades. As the framework conditions evolve in different academic and related policy spaces, the processes of capital accumulation and conversion for scholars active in these transnational fields also undergo changes, charting new geographies of knowledge transfer/exchange and academic synergy.

Let us now turn to examine the fate of social capital. Generally, academic mobility as a strategy to build linkages among scholars and affiliated institutions is marked with a celebratory tone in policy papers, related studies and general discourse. 'Establishing and strengthening linkages', 'renewing connections' and 'expanding networks' are indeed a few of the frequently cited positive impacts of academic mobility among my research participants. Nevertheless, as Willis reminds us:

> Mobility may also rupture or strain social relationship, leading to a decline in wellbeing if these relationships continue to be viewed as important by the individuals concerned. (2010, ix)

Li Xinxin (male, mid-20s), a post-doctoral fellow specialising in artificial intelligence and numerical simulation revealed worries when he pondered the potential negative impact of having left China:

> Ten years ago, if you came back with a foreign degree, you could become a professor immediately. Now it is so common to have foreign degrees. You also have to start with a junior position. And since you are not one of their kind, they might set a higher standard for you.

Zheng Nian (female, early-30s), a post-doctoral fellow in psychology, commented on the speedy development in her field in China and the problem of having been away from her institution for 'too long':

> When I returned to China, I realised that things happen so quickly here and so much had changed [in my field] while I was away. I often have a feeling that I cannot catch up with this pace. … I am sure I made personal advancement [in Germany]. That is certain. But I am not sure what advantage that would give me relative to others. … China has changed so fast in recent years. If you come back one year too late, all the job opportunities might be gone.

Isolation from the webs of social relationships 'back home' in China, in one's discipline or even one's institution, can be particularly influential in the Chinese context where changes take place at rocket speed and personal relationships ('*guānxi*') play an instrumental role in resource distribution. This 'fear' of being left behind or left aside was particular noticeable among younger scholars (especially post-doctoral fellows) who were not yet established in the Chinese academic circle. While e-communication allows real-time contacts, the power of face-to-face interactions is emphasised by many interviews. As a matter of fact, that also explains why scholars go on overseas research visits even though a substantive amount of their collaborative work can be achieved via the internet.

The accumulation of symbolic capital is examined by gauging the level of reputation, prestige and status and hence power attached to the scholars' mobility biography per se and its subsequent impact. About 40 per cent (49 out of 123) of my survey respondents gave 'very relevant' ('5' in a scale of '1' to '5') and 24 per cent (29) gave 'relevant' ('4' in a scale of '1' to '5') to the prestige of his/her fellowship as a motivation for their visits, reflecting the symbolic value of their endeavour. Even though overseas experience is increasingly common among Chinese scholars, it is still considered a privilege to be able to enjoy such mobility, especially when they are affiliated with 'world class' prestigious institutions overseas (cf. Xiang and Shen (2009) on the role of foreign university degrees and social stratification in China). All interviews and survey participants consider transnational academic mobility as prestigious and a positive symbolic capital for their career development, working in tandem with the accumulation of cultural and social capital as illustrated above. Shortly before his return to China, Li Xinxin speculated that his post-doc experience in one of the best institutions in his field would help his career when we discussed the role of reputation and prestige arising from transnational academic mobility:

> Leung: Do you think your overseas experiences would be important for your career development?
>
> Li: Certainly! Because if I stayed in China, I am sure I would forever stay very far from the core [of success, excellence]. It is like if I would be three steps from the core if I stayed in China. Now, from here, I think I am basically one step away from it.
>
> Leung: So it is a big jump, a career jump.
>
> Li: Yes, at least a jump.

Finally, the economic impact of academic mobility will briefly be presented. The Chinese case presents interesting insights into the possible links between academic mobility and economic well-being. Somewhat different from the contexts in most advanced economies, 'outside practice' is commonly undertaken among Chinese

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academics. As described by Chen Fenghua (male, mid-30s), 'Professorship is a ticket to a goldmine.' What he referred to was his Department Head (male, early-40s) who is known to have earned multiple million RMB (Chinese currency, 1 Euro ≈ 9 RMB) in a recent year. While a professor's monthly salary in Chen's field (in social sciences) is usually a few thousand RMB, the professor status qualifies one in bidding for a large number of sizeable consulting projects tendered by public and private institutions. Although the ground work is mostly conducted by junior colleagues, the professor keeps the lion share of the consultancy fees. Relevant to our analysis here is that this professor is one that has been highly mobile. He has been post-doctoral fellow and visiting researcher in various North American and European universities and is well-embedded in extensive international networks. As interpreted by Chen, 'He has certainly benefited greatly from his travelling around. The snowballing effect is tremendous. He is getting very powerful.'

Academic mobility does not only convert to other forms of capital; the transformation of scholars' capital portfolio often contributes to further geographical mobility. The accumulation of human capital (e.g. professional competence), social capital (e.g. embeddedness in international network), economic capital (e.g. access to funding for travelling) and symbolic capital (e.g. reputation of possessing cosmopolitan distinctions) generally enhances the chances of obtaining further mobility opportunities among already mobile scholars. The results of my survey also reflect this accumulative effect. About 40 per cent (47 out of 123) of my survey respondents gave 'very relevant' ('5' in a scale of '1' to '5') and 28 per cent (34) gave 'relevant' ('4' in a scale of '1' to '5') to the statement that their initial academic visit to Germany had led to subsequent professional stays in Germany. Many interviewees also indicated during our interviews that their visit to Germany had led to or raised their interest in conducting professional visits to other foreign places. About 20 per cent (27 out of 123) of my survey respondents gave 'very relevant' ('5' in a scale of '1' to '5') and 28 per cent (35) gave 'relevant' ('4' in a scale of '1' to '5') to the statement that their initial academic visit to Germany had led to subsequent professional stays overseas (outside of Germany).

In the above, I have presented data that help illustrate the linkages between academic mobility and capital accumulation and depreciation, concentrating on the transformation of these individuals as scholars. As any individual embodies a number of identities, my interviewees should not be regarded as only their working selves. All except a few have, for instance, referred to their eye-opening travel experiences in Germany and across Europe gathered during weekends, before and/or after their academic visits. The privilege to be able to travel to far away places, often expressed in abundant photo-taking (and photo-showing back in China or in internet social media) and souvenir shopping (and gift-giving back home), can also be considered as an act of capital acquisition in China where overseas and costly travelling is a pastime limited to relatively few (Leung 2009). On the other end of the frequency spectrum, a few respondents considered their adoption of a religious faith as (one of) the most fundamental personal developments gained from their professionally motivated visits. Lin Hexing (female, early-30s), post-doctoral fellow in mathematics, became a devoted Christian during her time in Germany, and that has altered her worldview and work ethos fundamentally. She answered my question related to the 'duty' of transnational mobile academics in national development this way:

> To me, my connection to God is the most important. Which country is strong, which country weak is worldly matter. This question is of no important in the eyes of God. When you die, it does not matter if you come from a stronger, developed country or otherwise. That has nothing to do with salvation at all.

To this young scholar, getting to know God was the most important personal transformation that she had experienced on her journey to Germany. Through her adoption of the Christian faith, she had also acquired social capital in the form of a network with other church-goers who were predominantly Germans and non-academics. These social connections had in turn deepened her understanding of the German language and other aspects of her host society, which can be considered as cultural capital that is not so attainable by other Chinese visiting scholars who lack access to such contact zones. While Lin remained a hard-working scientist producing work of high quality, she had retreated from the 'mindless rat race' in academia to find time for soul searching – a decision that can be interpreted as counter-productive if only work-related achievements are used as the sole indicator of development. This example reminds us how mobility and capital accumulation or development should be analysed as dynamic, often unplannable, multi-faceted and highly contextualised processes. Academic mobility can intersect development in very different and sometimes contradictory or even conflictual ways that are to be traced in multiple but inter-linked social fields and at diverse spatial scales.

Conclusions

As knowledge economies become more connected globally, an increasing number of scholars have become more mobile, reaching beyond their home bases to tap into opportunities that would develop their capital

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portfolio. Admittedly, the need and ability to move differ greatly among individual scholars in different disciplines, situated in uneven political-economic geographies. Few would, however, argue against the general rise in the value of geographical mobility as capital for self- and professional development. This paper advances our understanding in the transnational(ising) academic field in three ways. Conceptually, it connects the vibrant mobilities research with work on capital by Bourdieu and built upon by others, and proposes an extension of the capital construct to include geographical mobility as a form of capital. This proposition represents an attempt, one of many arguably, at giving 'mobility' a centre stage (not as general background) in our analysis of the developmental processes that can be observed in international academia. Empirically it provides one of the first grounded analyses of mobility experiences among Chinese academics, with a focus on how mobility is conceived and practised as a resource to enhance personal and professional development among the scholars. Methodologically, this research operates with an agent-centred approach, focusing on the mobile individuals rather than on the policies and programmes that regulate academic mobility. This offers a deeper and more layered understanding of mobility as enacted and experienced by active social agents who (have to) consider and are regulated by the opportunity and constraint structures in their affiliated fields.

Development, operationalised as an expansion of varied sorts of capital, is studied here at the individual level. Illustrated with substantial interview and survey data, this paper has shown how individual research participants linked their academic mobility experiences with changes in their capital portfolio. Scholars and researchers, in almost all cases, have achieved a certain level of personal and professional development because of the opportunities they have in leaving (and afterwards returning to) their own institution, city, province, country and enter into another set of spaces, characterised with a particular constellation of academic 'hardware' (i.e. literature, equipment, facilities etc.) and 'software' (i.e. skills, knowledge, common work culture, accepted codes of conducts, value systems etc.). To be active in the transnational academic field does not mean that these individuals can always harvest the best of both worlds. The possibility to recognise, adopt, translate and transfer tangible or intangible elements of the various academic fields cannot be taken for granted. Personal traits of the scholars and framework conditions interact to produce or restrain spaces for synergy.

While the privilege to work overseas with the support from the Chinese government or their home institutions was predominantly considered positive and capital-generating, capital depreciation might also take place, especially with regard to embeddedness in social networks 'back home'. The convertibility of the mobility capital, like other forms of capital, is highly context (i.e. time/space)-specific. The social positioning of the mobile academics – shaped by one's age, position at work, gender, discipline background and the possession of relevant social, cultural and mobility capital – and nature of the journey/visit – duration, work nature, location, composition of colleagues, type of sponsorship etc. – interact to produce the profit-/loss-margin of a particular academic mobility project.

A focus on the individual level does not negate the importance of mobility-related development at more aggregated scales. Considered commonly as the 'best and brightest' and 'cultivators of our next generations', the role of these transnational academics in the creation and exchange of knowledge, an element that has become ever more important as a resource for regional and national development is obvious. The narratives illustrated have brought forth the organic processes in which mobility as resource contributes (or not) to personal development, which can in turn be harnessed for changes and development at aggregate levels. Conditions 'back home' are crucial factors in determining if and how much personal development gained through international academic mobility is appreciated and if and how it can/should be carried to make an impact at other and/or broader levels.

China is an intriguing case for the study of academic mobility and development. As China rises rapidly in the global power order, it has also pushed an enormous amount of resources into the development of its strategic scientific and academic infrastructure. While some laboratories or institutions are now considered as one of the best in the world, some are 'catching up' and others that are not considered as strategic suffer from (relative) poverty. One might argue that China is a special case (as in many other aspects); it is certainly not the only country where the academic field is a highly uneven terrain. The gradient of difference in 'academic excellence' travelled by mobile academics is often steeper if they move within the country than a visit to another institution with comparable resources and 'quality' overseas. How valid then are conventionally adopted, oft unquestioned, dichotomous categories (e.g. 'North/South', 'developed/developing countries') and the focus on the 'nation' in framing our inquiry into the developmental impact of academic mobility? I concur with Sidaway's (2012) recent call for nuanced, alternative critical mappings in studying (uneven) development. In order to move forward our understanding of the academic mobility–development nexus, we need to question conventions that automatically link individuals to a nation (from the 'North' or 'South' that suggest certain competencies and work 'culture') and prescribe a certain role in the international divi-

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sion/hierarchy of labour in the global knowledge economy. Only when we unsettle categories such as the 'knowledge provider' vis-à-vis the 'learner' on the academic mobility map can we liberate ourselves from making implicit assumptions about who is supposed to gain and grow when academic personnel from different geographical and social backgrounds come together.

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Notes

1 I have elaborated in another paper on this 'spatial bias' issue (Leung 2011).

2 In this paper, 'China' refers to the People's Republic of China (PRC), excluding the Special Administrative regions Hong Kong and Macau, and does not include Taiwan. 'Chinese' therefore denotes people and characteristics of the PRC.

3 See Leung (forthcoming) for a detailed discussion on the recent institutional changes that account for the increase in exchange and interactions among Chinese and German scholars.

4 See Leung (2011) on the notion of 'development corridor' as applied to this research.

5 Three months was chosen as the minimum length of stay to screen out very brief stays such as conference trips, project meetings and guest lecture visits. Length of stay is, however, not a direct indicator of connectivity and impact. Ackers (2010) calls for a need to recognise the impact of short (but recurrent) stays. Her recent study on medical professionals further underlines the need to pay attention to the discipline-specific temporalities of academic/professional mobility (Ackers forthcoming).

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